portions and epigraphy are also applicable to the known – though no longer surviving – *minar* at Qasimabad, near Zahidan (before AH 559/1164 CE) (Figure 2.18), about 240 km southwest of Zaranj-Nad-i Ali (in modern Iran's Sistan and Baluchistan Province). Qasimabad's equally elaborate epigraphic program apparently did not refer to Saljuq authority, mentioning instead two of the rulers of the local Nasri *malik*s of Nimruz/Sistan,[45] though the *minar*'s overall format certainly derived from western architectural–cultural ideas.

In the sense of coming from the "outside," both the Saljuqs and the emerging Shansabanis formed a contrast to the hegemonic power of the Ghaznavids, already entrenched in the Ghazna region by the end of the tenth century. While the Shansabanis eventually emerged from the anonymity of central Afghanistan's nomad–urban continuum, the Ghaznavids' progenitors had been youths captured as slaves from Eurasia's eastern Turkic steppes. But thereafter, these youths were effectively incorporated into royal service farther west, absorbed into and reared within the influential Samanids' (ninth–tenth centuries) courtly ethos as *ghulam*s and important courtiers on the rise (cf. Introduction). They were Turks who had nonetheless become *in*siders of the tenth-century Samanid court: the elite environment *par excellence*, the crucible that forged courtly styles and tastes especially *via* Persian literary production (as well as Arabic), casting long shadows over the following centuries of cultural patronage and consumption – the "Persianate millennium."[46] Indeed, we recall the supplanting of a purely Turkic origin for Mahmud Ghaznavi's father Sabuktigin (d. AH 421/999 CE) with a mixed Sasanian genealogy (cf. Introduction, notes).[47] As the Samanids waned and their *ghulam*s increased their independence in the



Figure 1.7 Mihrab *of mosque at Sin, north of Isfahan,* c. *1132 CE. © Photograph Alka Patel 2011.*



Figure 1.8 Minar *of mosque complex, Sin,* c. *1134–1135 CE. © Photograph Alka Patel 2011.*